



Conceptualizing Business Process Management Governance: Towards a Context-aware Understanding

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Received: 1 October 2024 / Accepted: 22 November 2025
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Abstract Business Process Management (BPM) is a pivotal driver of operational excellence and sustained organizational performance. To effectively institutionalize BPM at the enterprise level, organizations must establish a robust BPM governance (BPM-G) that provides structure and guidance for all BPM activities. Despite its recognized importance in industry and academia, there remains a need for a comprehensive conceptualization of BPM-G, particularly concerning its configurational diversity and embedding in the organizational context. In response, we develop a tax-

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onomy of BPM-G based on justificatory knowledge from the literature on BPM and corporate governance, as well as interview data from a diverse set of organizations. We demonstrate and evaluate the taxonomy in three steps, presenting three illustrative cases that showcase the usefulness of the taxonomy for describing and analyzing BPM-G. Based on the evaluated taxonomy as our primary contribution, we then advance a context-aware understanding of BPM-G. We specify the relation between BPM-G and corporate governance as well as process governance, discussing how the design of BPM-G is influenced by the organizational tensions of centralization vs. decentralization and standardization vs. flexibilization.

Keywords Business Process Management Governance · Taxonomy Development · Corporate Governance · Organizational Tensions · Conceptual Framework

1 Introduction

Business processes are central to how corporations organize work, deliver products and services, and execute their strategy (Hammer 2015; van Looy et al. 2022). As business processes span multiple departments and require cross-functional coordination, their management has become a key organizational task. Business Process Management (BPM) focuses on the methods and tools needed for the effective design, execution, improvement, and monitoring of business processes (Dumas et al. 2018). Hence, when adopting BPM on the enterprise level, organizations must establish clear structures, roles, and responsibilities that provide guidance and boundaries for their BPM activities (Kerpedzhiev et al. 2021; Vom Brocke et al. 2014), which is commonly referred to as BPM governance (BPM-G) (Spanyi 2015).

BPM-G determines the way BPM is embedded in an organization, e.g., through a dedicated team, formal roles, or mechanisms of continuous process improvement (Hernaus et al. 2016; Danilova 2019; Schmiedel and Vom Brocke 2015). Research shows that organizations design and implement BPM-G in various ways (e.g., Alibabaei 2021; Santana et al. 2011). For example, BPM-G can encompass a mix of centralized and decentralized roles, a center of excellence that provides organization-wide capabilities, or specialized units that focus on specific BPM activities such as process modeling (Arsanjani et al. 2015; Dyer et al. 2013; Rosemann 2015). Despite being one of the six success factors of BPM (Kerpedzhiev et al. 2021), BPM-G still presents organizations with significant challenges given the variety of possible setups (Vom Brocke et al. 2022).

One of the key issues is that BPM-G cannot be designed in isolation, but must consider its context (Vom Brocke et al. 2016; 2022). Thereby, context can be understood as the internal and external organizational environment in which BPM-G is designed, embedded, and practiced (Rosemann et al. 2006). Most importantly, BPM-G is linked to an organization's overarching corporate governance (Aguilera et al. 2018; Tihanyi et al. 2014), which includes all mechanisms, structures, and practices through which organizational activities are controlled and operated across hierarchy levels (Tricker 2015; Daily et al. 2003). Designing corporate governance involves balancing the tension-inducing trade-off between enforcing control

and granting freedom (Langfred and Rockmann 2016). These tensions are also relevant to more specialized governance forms for organizational functions such as finance (Bebchuk et al. 2009), for digital technologies such as AI (Wareham et al. 2014), or for management disciplines such as innovation (Klingebiel and Rammer 2014). Among these specific governance forms, BPM-G takes a distinct role as business processes are not bound by individual organizational functions or technologies (Hammer 2015; Rosemann and Vom Brocke 2015). Rather, its cross-functional scope allows BPM to improve how work is done, necessitating alignment across the organization and with other governance forms.

To that end, organizations need to be able to weigh different design options for BPM-G against each other (Vom Brocke et al. 2021b). However, a comprehensive conceptualization of what BPM-G constitutes is missing. Compared to other governance forms, such as finance (e.g., Shleifer and Vishny (1997)), or other BPM success factors such as methods (e.g., Grisold et al. 2022), BPM-G remains understudied. Research so far focuses on individual elements of BPM-G, e.g., process ownership (Hernaus et al. 2016), or specific setups, e.g., the center of excellence (Rosemann 2015). These insights are often bound to single case studies, which are valuable for an in-depth understanding but offer limited generalizability. Hence, it remains unclear which dimensions constitute BPM-G, which characteristics can be chosen and combined (e.g., a mix of decentralized roles with a centralized unit), and how BPM-G should be aligned with and embedded in its organizational context (e.g., corporate governance).

Generating such a comprehensive conceptualization of BPM-G is relevant for research, as it not only enables the systematic analysis of BPM-G but also contributes to a more context-aware understanding of BPM and its relation to corporate governance (Gregor 2006; Gregor and Hevner 2013). For example, such insights may inform ongoing discussions on how organizational tensions known from corporate governance, e.g., those stemming from the need to balance control and autonomy, manifest in the governance of cross-functional management disciplines like BPM-G (Joseph and Sengul 2025). From a practical perspective, such knowledge would support clear-headed decisions when adopting BPM by outlining design options and contextual dependencies. Against this backdrop, our research question is: *How can BPM-G be conceptualized and how does it relate to its context?*

To address the first part of our research question, we aim to identify the dimensions and characteristics that constitute BPM-G. Accordingly, we apply Nickerson et al.'s (2013) and Kundisch et al.'s (2021) taxonomy development approach to build a taxonomy of BPM-G. For the empirical-to-conceptual (E2C) iterations, we conduct interviews with 21 BPM practitioners from 18 organizations. For the conceptual-to-empirical (C2E) iterations, we build on corporate governance and BPM literature as justificatory knowledge. We group the dimensions of the taxonomy according to two key tensions that emerged from the interviews as highly relevant for BPM-G: *centralization vs. decentralization* and *standardization vs. flexibilization*. To demonstrate and evaluate the taxonomy, we classify the BPM-G setup¹ of

¹ The term “BPM-G setup” is used throughout this paper to refer to the specific instantiation of BPM-G in a given organization.

14 organizations, conduct ten additional expert interviews, and present three illustrative cases in-depth. To address the second part of our research question, we use the evaluated taxonomy to discuss how BPM-G relates to its organizational context. As a theory for analyzing (Gregor 2006), the evaluated taxonomy is our first and primary contribution. It offers a conceptualization of BPM-G (Kundisch et al. 2021) that other scholars can use to advance BPM-G research and to systematically analyze BPM-G. The second contribution of our study lies in advancing a context-aware understanding of BPM-G.

The remainder of this study is structured as follows. In Section 2, we provide the theoretical background of corporate governance and BPM-G to develop a conceptual framework that clarifies the focus and scope of our research. In Section 3, we outline the research design for developing and evaluating the taxonomy. We present the taxonomy in Section 4, before reporting on the evaluation in Section 5. In Section 6, we advance our contextual understanding of BPM-G and discuss our study's contribution and implications. We conclude in Section 7 with limitations and directions for future research.

2 Theoretical Background

Governance is a highly configurational and context-dependent topic, as its effectiveness depends on organizational, institutional, and strategic conditions (Aguilera et al. 2018). BPM-G is situated at the intersection of strategic intent, structural design, and operational execution of business processes, extending across functional and hierarchical boundaries. As justificatory knowledge, we therefore draw on two major research streams. First, we incorporate foundational insights from the mature body of knowledge on corporate governance. Within this stream, we emphasize the role of organizational tensions, which are central to how governance works in corporate contexts. Second, we engage with the literature on BPM in general and BPM-G in particular. On that foundation, we operationalize our research focus and scope by developing a conceptual framework that situates BPM-G within its context and by formulating an updated definition of BPM-G.

2.1 Corporate Governance and Organizational Tensions

Corporate governance “deals with mechanisms by which stakeholders of a corporation exercise control over corporate insiders and management such that their interests are protected” (John and Senbet 1998, p. 372). It encompasses fundamental decisions about how authority is allocated, accountability is ensured, and strategic direction is maintained in alignment with stakeholder interests (Daily et al. 2003; Tihanyi et al. 2014). While traditionally rooted in economics, law, and finance (e.g., Shleifer and Vishny 1997; Fama and Jensen 1998), governance has also become an important topic of business research as a dynamic and multi-level concept that goes beyond legal compliance and board oversight (Aguilera and Jackson 2003; Ostrom 2005).

Corporate governance extends into various organizational domains depending on the object that is being governed. First, some governance forms are functionally

anchored and target specific organizational functions, such as IT or finance, aiming to align decisions, accountability, and monitoring within their respective domains (Weill and Ross 2004; Shleifer and Vishny 1997). Second, governance forms focus on the management of organizational resources or outputs, such as data or digital technologies, where governance ensures quality, compliance, and responsible use (Otto 2011; Papagiannidis et al. 2025). Third, governance may address cross-functional management disciplines such as BPM or innovation, which cut across formal structures as well as resources and outputs, requiring an integrative mechanism for coordination and control (Klingebiel and Rammer 2014; Rosemann and Vom Brocke 2015). While the first two types are typically embedded in traditional line functions, the latter pose design challenges due to their distributed and integrative character.

Despite their specific focus, all governance forms are embedded in and must align with an organization's overarching corporate governance. At each level, designing governance requires deliberate design decisions to navigate organizational tensions. Among these tensions, one fundamental trade-off stands out: the balance between control and autonomy (Foss 2003; Puranam et al. 2012). A trade-off describes a situation in which two competing demands can coexist but cannot be realized at their full strength at the same time (Gaim et al. 2018; Kerpedzhiev et al. 2024). Navigating such tensions cannot be geared solely towards efficiency, but must reflect broader organizational strategies, environmental contingencies, and political considerations (Aguilera et al. 2008). Therefore, governance is not just a structural arrangement, but a mechanism for enabling or constraining behavior in line with an organization's objectives (Greenwood et al. 2011). As such, organizational tensions are not confined to corporate governance, but are often inherited and amplified within domain-specific governance settings, particularly as organizational scale and environmental complexity increase (Smith and Lewis 2011; Jarzabkowski et al. 2013).

The literature underscores that governance is not only about defining principles or allocating formal authority, but also about how those principles are translated into reality. Considering the inherent tensions in governance design, organizations must decide how governance is structured, operationalized, and put into day-to-day business (Foss 2003; Puranam et al. 2012). This includes configuring roles and responsibilities, coordination mechanisms, and accountability structures (Greenwood et al. 2011; Smith and Lewis 2011). As such, we see the design of BPM-G not as an isolated endeavor, but as highly dependent on the organizational context and organizational tensions of governance design (Aguilera and Jackson 2003; Leonhardt et al. 2018).

2.2 Business Processes Management and Governance

A business process is “a collection of interrelated events, activities, and decision points that involve a number of actors and objects, which collectively lead to an outcome that is of value to at least one customer” (Dumas et al. 2018, p. 6). BPM is the “body of methods, techniques, and tools to identify, discover, analyze, redesign, execute, and monitor business processes in order to optimize their performance” (Dumas et al. 2018, p. 6). Main research areas of interest include BPM maturity (e.g., Bandara et al. 2021); adoption (e.g., Schmiedel et al. 2020); methods (e.g.,

Grisold et al. 2022); capabilities (e.g., Kerpedzhiev et al. 2021; Lehnert et al. 2016) as well as process technologies such as process mining and robotic process automation (van der Aalst 2016).

Within these discussions, BPM-G has emerged as a critical success factor for adopting BPM at the enterprise level, where alignment, coordination, and sustainability become essential (de Bruin and Rosemann 2007; Rosemann and Vom Brocke 2015; Ensslin et al. 2017). To do so, BPM-G “creates the right structures, metrics, roles, and responsibilities to measure and manage the performance of a firm’s end-to-end business processes” (Spanyi 2015, p. 333). Enterprise-wide BPM adoption, however, implies a governance challenge in two directions, each entailing its own tensions: On the one hand, organizations must structure and position their BPM-G in line with the broader corporate governance in a way that considers other connected governance forms (e.g., IT governance) and enables the cross-functional role of BPM (Doebeli et al. 2011; Khusidman 2010). On the other hand, organizations need to ensure that all business processes are effectively managed and governed in their day-to-day execution. While this operational coordination of business processes falls into the area of process governance (Lynne and Jacobson 2015), BPM-G defines the structures and boundaries in which process governance operates, e.g., in terms of standards and methods applied.

Research on BPM-G has focused on individual elements of BPM-G, e.g., process ownership (Danilova 2019), the role of BPM teams (Hernaus et al. 2016), specific setups like centers of excellence (Santana et al. 2011; Dyer et al. 2013; von Rosing et al. 2014), as well as drivers and barriers during the implementation of BPM (Valenca et al. 2013; Scott et al. 2012). For example, process owners play a critical role in ensuring accountability and continuous improvement within BPM initiatives, while a dedicated BPM team facilitates focused efforts (Danilova 2019). Most of these studies emphasize the importance of organizational context as a key determinant in designing an effective BPM-G (de Boer et al. 2015; Santana et al. 2011), but treat context as a background condition rather than an explicit construct. For example, it is argued that BPM-G should evolve in line with an organization’s BPM maturity, adapting governance mechanisms as capabilities develop (de Boer et al. 2015). Yet, despite these acknowledgments, the notion of context itself remains conceptually vague in the BPM-G literature (Vom Brocke et al. 2021a).

Building on prior work on context-aware BPM (Rosemann et al. 2006; Vom Brocke et al. 2016; Zelt et al. 2019), we understand context as the internal and external environment in which BPM-G is designed, embedded and practiced. The internal environment refers to the organizational factors that influence BPM-G, such as structure, size, decision rights, and available capabilities (van Looy and van den Bergh 2018; Kerpedzhiev et al. 2021). For instance, BPM-G may be designed differently when embedded in an ongoing digital transformation or as part of an enterprise-wide excellence initiative, compared to situations where BPM is newly introduced or limited to specific departments such as IT (Baiyere et al. 2020). Likewise, firms with a long tradition of continuous improvement and strong process culture will approach BPM-G differently from those where such a culture is still emerging. The external environment captures influences from outside the organizations, including market dynamics, regulatory frameworks, technological change, and institutional

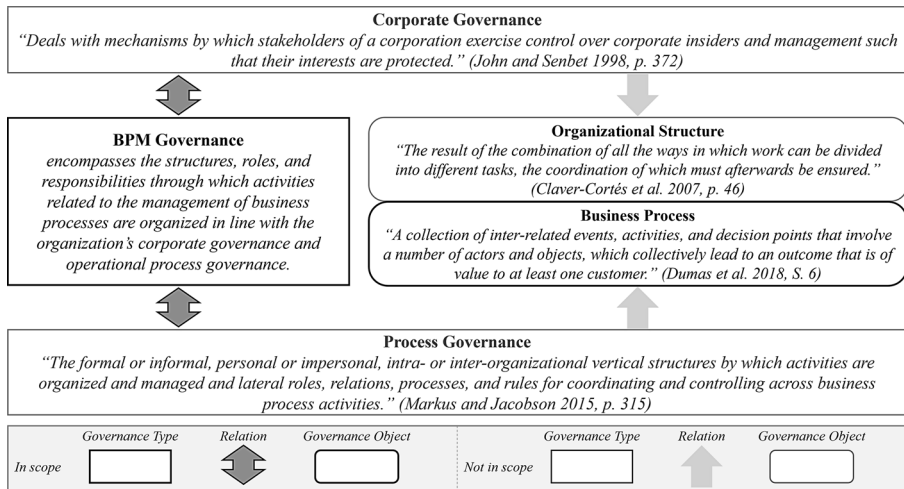


Fig. 1 Conceptual framework—Situating BPM-G within its contexts

expectations (Ostrom 2005; Edvardsson et al. 2018). Fast-moving digital markets may encourage more adaptive governance forms that allow rapid experimentation, whereas stable or tradition-bound sectors often favor more formalized approaches to ensure reliability. Moreover, exogenous shifts, such as those caused by sudden disruptions in the economic, technological, or societal landscape, can fundamentally alter the conditions under which BPM-G operates by triggering abrupt changes in priorities, resources, or coordination needs (Röglinger et al. 2022).

2.3 Situating Business Process Management Governance Within Its Contexts

Considering the presented work, we now introduce a conceptual framework that situates BPM-G within its organizational context, clarifies our understanding of BPM-G, and delineates the scope of our study (Fig. 1). The framework forms the foundation for our research, guides the taxonomy development process, and supports our theorizing. Therein, BPM-G acts as an interface that translates external requirements into internal structures and practices, linking BPM to both corporate governance and process governance. In the following, we elaborate on its key aspects.

It is common practice that organizations organize and govern work both based on *organizational structures* (i.e., functions) (Claver-Cortés et al. 2007) and *business processes* (Rosemann and Vom Brocke 2015; Dumas et al. 2018). Thereby, business processes span the value creation process in a cross-functional manner, linking parts of the organization toward shared outcomes (Keidel 1994; Kohlbacher and Gruenwald 2011). While BPM itself is not part of the value creation process, it can only unfold its full potential if it is meaningfully embedded in the organizational context, connecting it to all organizational structures and business processes (Lynne and Jacobson 2015; Spanyi 2015; Ensslin et al. 2017). BPM-G plays a pivotal role in enabling this embedding. We therefore see the need to refine our understanding of BPM-G and extend prior definitions (e.g., by Spanyi 2015) to incorporate its

context-dependency. In our study, we define it as follows: *BPM-G encompasses the structures, roles, and responsibilities through which activities related to the management of business processes are organized in line with the organization's corporate governance and operational process governance.*

With this definition, we emphasize the essential role of BPM-G for BPM while situating it within its context *by linking it to corporate governance and process governance.* In terms of corporate governance, we are interested in how BPM-G relates to the overarching mechanisms, structures, and practices through which organizations coordinate and control *all* work. For instance, a highly centralized corporate governance approach may conflict with a BPM-G that offers a high degree of autonomy (Danilova 2019; Hernaus et al. 2016). Regarding process governance, we focus on how BPM-G structures and constrains the operational management and execution of business processes (Aguilera and Jackson 2003; Puranam et al. 2012). Although these conceptual links are acknowledged in research, the interplay between BPM-G, corporate governance, and process governance remains insufficiently understood. Specifically, little is known about their mutual dependencies and the tensions that arise from their interaction (Gaim et al. 2018). This lack of conceptual integration limits our ability to offer guidance on how BPM-G should be designed to remain consistent, accepted, and adaptable in complex organizational settings (Smith and Lewis 2011; Leonhardt et al. 2018).

Against this background, we aim to provide a comprehensive conceptualization of BPM-G. To do so, we adopt a taxonomy development approach, which allows for the identification and classification of patterns in the BPM-G of organizations. Taxonomies are well-established methodological instruments in research when aiming to structure complex, multidimensional phenomena and concepts (Kundisch et al. 2021; Eggers et al. 2023). In line with this tradition, we aim to conceptualize BPM-G with our taxonomy not as a one-size-fits-all solution, but as a flexible, context-sensitive governance configuration. We then use the taxonomy to explore the relationship between BPM-G, corporate governance, and process governance and refine our conceptual framework.

3 Research Design

We adopted a two-stage research approach (Fig. 2). First, we followed Nickerson et al.'s (2013) and Kundisch et al.'s (2021) taxonomy development process to build a taxonomy of BPM-G. We iterated between E2C and C2E phases and evaluated the emerging taxonomy at each step. Second, we demonstrated and evaluated the taxonomy's applicability and usefulness. To do so, we classified the BPM-G setup of 14 organizations, conducted ten additional expert interviews, and built three illustrative cases.

3.1 Taxonomy Development

We applied Nickerson et al.'s (2013) taxonomy development method, which has been widely applied in business and IS research (Kundisch et al. 2021). The method begins

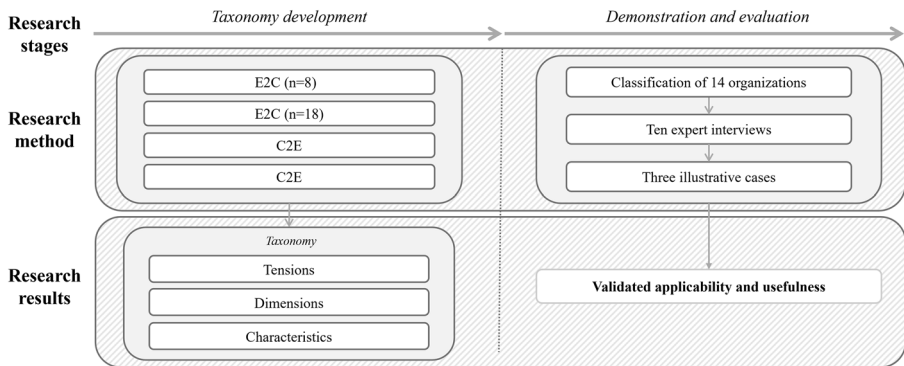


Fig. 2 Two-stage research approach

by formulating a *meta-characteristic*, which is the overarching structuring element defining the taxonomy's purpose and guides the identification of *dimensions* and *characteristics*. Subsequently, defining subjective and objective ending conditions ensured that the iterative development process is stopped once the taxonomy meets predefined quality criteria. Each iteration of the development process follows either the E2C, i.e., inductive reasoning, or the C2E approach, i.e., deductive reasoning. At the end of each iteration, all ending conditions are tested. The next iteration begins if at least one ending condition is not met.

We defined our meta-characteristic as *organizational characteristics for BPM-G*. The subjective ending conditions are mandatory quality criteria that require our taxonomy to be concise, robust, comprehensive, extendible, and explanatory (Nickerson et al. 2013). We stated three objective ending conditions: *Every dimension is unique and not repeated; every characteristic is unique within its dimension; no new dimensions or characteristics were added in the last iteration*. We conducted two E2C and two C2E iterations during the taxonomy development process until all ending conditions were met (Table 1). We performed evaluation cycles during all iterations by checking the subjective ending conditions (Kundisch et al. 2021). Consistent with prior work on organizational setups (Jöhnik et al. 2007; Marcus et al. 2024), we allowed dimensions to be exclusive or non-exclusive, i.e., multiple characteristics can be applied to a non-exclusive dimension of BPM-G. For better traceability, Appendix A shows the taxonomy's versions after each iteration.

We started the taxonomy development process with an E2C iteration for two reasons. First, after an intensive screening of the BPM literature, we concluded that the current body of knowledge is not suited for a strictly theoretical approach, as it lacks a comprehensive perspective on what constitutes BPM-G. Like other taxonomy studies (e.g., Oberländer et al. 2018), we hence decided to initiate our research by drawing on empirical data before turning to theory to inform and challenge the preliminary results. Second, considering calls in the BPM literature for more empirical research (Klun and Trkman 2018), BPM-G is a practical topic where information on specific setups is not publicly available.

Throughout both E2C iterations, we leveraged qualitative semi-structured interviews with practitioners (Jöhnik et al. 2007; Myers and Newman 2007) to systemat-

Table 1 Overview of taxonomy development

Iteration	1	2	3	4
<i>Development</i>	E2C	E2C	C2E	C2E
<i>Approach</i>	8 organizations (9 interviews)	+10 new organizations (total = 18) (21 interviews)	18 organizations (re-evaluation of prior interviews)	18 organizations (re-evaluation of prior interviews)
<i>Empirical basis</i>	BPM & BPM Governance			
<i>Theoretical basis</i>	–	–	Corporate Governance & Organizational Tensions	
<i>Major activities</i>	Development of first dimensions & characteristics	Addition of activities within BPM; introduction of hierarchical logic	Addition of new characteristics; specification of existing characteristics	Review of gathered data & introduction of guiding questions
<i>Data analysis</i>	Inductive open, axial, and selective coding; coding supported by constant comparison between interviews	Iterative axial coding; consolidation of categories into layers; emerging recognition of tension-related design trade-offs	Deductive coding against corporate governance and organizational tension literature	Iterative comparison of taxonomy with grey literature; final synthesis
<i>Evaluation activities</i>	Internal discussion among authors to cluster codes into first-order concepts	Practitioner feedback through interviews (21 practitioners)	Workshop with BPM researchers; workshop among authors	Workshop among authors and review of professional literature
<i>Violated ending condition</i>	Objective: dimensions and characteristics were added in the last iteration	Objective: dimensions and characteristics were added in the last iteration	Objective: dimensions and characteristics were added in the last iteration	–

ically discuss our subject of interest. Being flexible with a pre-defined set of topics and questions, while offering room to explore so far undiscovered topics, made insights accessible that could not be obtained from publicly available sources. Concerning the choice of participants, we aimed to interview professionals who either supervise, lead, or work in a BPM department or team. We combined a purposive sampling strategy (Marton 2013) with expert sampling (Bhattacharjee 2012), aiming for diverse organizations in size and industry. We sent interview requests to 29 practitioners from the authors' professional networks for the selection process. In total, 21 practitioners from 18 organizations were willing to participate in the interviews, resulting in 21 semi-structured interviews, with an average duration of 45 min. Table A5 in Appendix B shows the interviewees' roles, experience in BPM, and each organization's industry. All interviews were audio-recorded and subsequently transcribed for analysis.

In the *first iteration (E2C)*, we interviewed nine BPM practitioners from eight organizations (I1–I9). One author introduced the research topic and asked the interviewee to describe their organization's BPM-G (see Appendix C for the interview guide), whereafter we discussed individual elements of the setup. Following each interview, we met with the entire author team to compare notes and discuss new insights. After having conducted all interviews for this iteration, we followed an inductive coding approach for data analysis (e.g., Gioia et al. 2013; Wolfswinkel et al. 2013; Strauss and Corbin 1990). Through open coding, we screened the interview transcripts and collected quotes in which the interviewee described specific facets of their BPM-G. Staying as close as possible to the original statement, we then grouped similar open codes and phrased them as characteristics of BPM-G to develop our first-order concepts. Through axial coding, we then continuously clustered these concepts into second-order themes, reflecting dimensions along which organizations design BPM-G. Through selective coding, we then grouped the second-order themes into layers that structure the dimensions, an approach commonly used in taxonomy design to enhance clarity and usability. The resulting coding scheme allowed us to form an initial version of the taxonomy, consisting of layers, dimensions, and characteristics, which we updated throughout all following iterations. We also formulated initial guiding questions that reflect each dimension's purpose and facilitate later use of the taxonomy. As we just started the taxonomy development in this iteration, the objective ending conditions were not met.

In the *second iteration (E2C)*, we interviewed another twelve BPM practitioners from ten organizations (I10–I21). Following the same coding approach as in the first iteration, the goal of this phase was to adjust and complement the already discovered dimensions and characteristics. One key learning of this analysis was that the interviewees consistently mentioned the tension-inducing endeavor of balancing trade-offs when designing BPM-G. For example, we found that the organizational anchoring of BPM-G connects to the trade-off between the centralization or decentralization of BPM activities. While we were not yet able to fully capture all nuances of these tensions, we formulated an initial set and used them as a layer to group the dimensions and characteristics of BPM-G. We ended the second iteration with a taxonomy version of more than 20 dimensions and 70 characteristics. The ending conditions were not met as we added dimensions and characteristics, and

the taxonomy was not concise and precise enough. We also realized that interviews yielded fewer new insights and wanted to learn more about existing knowledge on the identified tensions. Thus, we decided to continue with a C2E iteration.

In the *third iteration (C2E)*, we aimed to refine the dimensions and characteristics identified in the previous two iterations through insights from literature. On the one hand, we consulted BPM literature not with the primary intent of identifying new dimensions, but to validate and sharpen those dimensions already derived from the interviews. To achieve this, we started with the BPM-G studies that we had screened before initiating the first iteration. Additionally, we conducted an assessing review (Leidner 2018) of BPM literature. We used established databases such as Google Scholar, AIS eLibrary, and Web of Science, and specifically searched for terms identical or similar to the dimensions identified in earlier iterations, e.g., (“Business Process Management” OR “BPM”) AND (“Governance”) AND (“role”). This allowed us to map relevant sources from BPM research to each dimension, ensuring our taxonomy was theoretically grounded, and to selectively adjust and enrich several characteristics. On the other hand, we drew on justificatory knowledge from corporate governance literature to deepen our understanding of the identified organizational tensions. Given the breadth of the field and the often implicit treatment of such tensions, we assessed seminal works with a narrow lens on conflicts, challenges, or trade-offs inherent in governance design (Leidner 2018; Vom Brocke et al. 2015). From there, we examined subsequent studies addressing tension-inducing mechanisms, such as the trade-off between autonomy and control, until we had gathered a foundational understanding of organizational tensions in corporate governance. We presented the key insights from this review in Section 2.1. Throughout the taxonomy development and evaluation process, we continuously revisited this body of knowledge to refine our conceptual understanding of the tensions and their role for BPM-G. In this iteration, we were therefore able to finalize the layers of the taxonomy by conceptualizing them as two central organizational tensions in BPM-G design, i.e., the trade-offs of *centralization vs. decentralization* and *standardization vs. flexibilization*. We mapped each dimension to one of these tensions to establish a conceptual structure through which the taxonomy reflects the strategic trade-offs inherent in BPM-G.

To evaluate the intermediate taxonomy in this iteration, we conducted a workshop within the author team. We systematically revisited all gathered data as well as integrated and discussed how well the identified dimensions and characteristics reflected the empirical and theoretical insights gathered so far. Particularly, we assessed whether the taxonomy remained sufficiently abstract while still being applicable across various organizational contexts. As a result, we eliminated those dimensions that we rated as too specific, such as the details about which units, other than the people responsible for BPM, enact BPM activities. In addition, we discussed the current version with other BPM researchers from our professional network. Their feedback confirmed the clarity and relevance of the identified dimensions and tensions. As we continued to refine and expand the taxonomy during this iteration, the objective ending conditions remained unmet, and we decided to engage in a fourth iteration.

In the *fourth iteration (C2E)*, we revisited the academic literature which had served as sources in the third iteration. Further, we screened the practitioner literature to validate the dimensions and characteristics of the taxonomy and ensure alignment with key concepts in BPM and corporate governance. We cross-referenced the current version of the taxonomy with professional, i.e., “grey”, literature from BPM associations, communities, and consultancies (e.g., Khusidman 2010) to ensure that it incorporates dimensions and characteristics most relevant to practice. In addition, we adjusted the guiding questions based on the findings of our last iteration by formulating them in a way that directly addresses prospective users of the taxonomy, e.g., BPM practitioners. At the end of this iteration, we confirmed all dimensions, characteristics, and tensions and validated our findings by applying the taxonomy to the BPM-G setup of 18 organizations. Thereafter, we all agreed that all ending conditions were met and that the taxonomy development process was finished.

3.2 Demonstration and Evaluation of the Taxonomy

Demonstrating and evaluating a taxonomy is vital to ensure it is appropriate for its purpose (Kundisch et al. 2021; Nickerson et al. 2013). We decided on *applicability* and *usefulness* as evaluation criteria for this research stage (Kundisch et al. 2021). Table 2 summarizes our three demonstration and evaluation steps. We pursued a strategy that combines both an operational application of the taxonomy’s descriptive capacity (*applicability*) and an exploratory examination of its conceptual value for understanding and guiding organizational design (*usefulness*). This combination allowed us to assess its robustness across different levels of abstraction.

First, we used the final version of the taxonomy to classify the BPM-G setup of 18 organizations that were part of the first and second development iterations. We then asked the respective BPM practitioners, i.e., our interviewees, to provide feedback on the overall understandability of the taxonomy and to validate or adjust our proposed classification. The complete questionnaire can be found in Appendix D. We received feedback of 14 organizations and, based on their adjustments, calculated Cohen’s Kappa, which measures the level of agreement between judges (Nahm et al. 2002; Landis and Koch 1977; Moore and Benbasat 1991). As for the validity of our taxonomy, we calculated the hit ratios of the classification (Moore and Benbasat 1991; Nahm et al. 2002). Appendix E shows the classification results, and Appendix F the calculation of Cohen’s Kappa and hit ratio.

Second, we conducted another set of ten semi-structured expert interviews (Myers and Newman 2007) with BPM practitioners from nine organizations (Kundisch et al. 2021). In contrast to the first evaluation step, our aim was to deepen our understanding of the taxonomy’s usefulness for guiding discussions on BPM-G without offering a pre-classification. We selected a heterogeneous set of organizations, including five that had participated in earlier stages of this research as well as four new ones to gain fresh insights into the topic (see Appendix B for further details). This mix enabled us to balance prior familiarity with the taxonomy’s development with novel, unbiased perspectives. Each interview started with a detailed examination and explanation of the taxonomy. We then asked the BPM practitioners to give

Table 2 Overview of demonstration and evaluation steps after taxonomy development

	Step	1	2	3
<i>Demonstration and evaluation</i>	<i>Approach</i>	Classification validation	Expert reflection interviews	Illustrative cases
	<i>Empirical basis</i>	14 organizations (subset of sample)	9 organizations (10 additional expert interviews)	3 organizations (I1, I4, I9)
	<i>Major activities</i>	Classification of each BPM-G setup using the taxonomy	Exploration of taxonomy's usefulness for analyzing BPM-G design decisions	In-depth application of taxonomy to describe organizational setups and contextual rationales
	<i>Data analysis</i>	Quantitative comparison of researcher vs. practitioner classification (Cohen's $\kappa = 0.54$; Hit ratio = 63.9%)	Thematic coding of interview transcripts to extract rationale patterns	Cross-case analysis based on coded dimensions
	<i>Evaluation focus</i>	Validation of applicability and consistency	Usefulness for reflection and guidance	Demonstration of context-aware application
	<i>Outcome</i>	Confirmed applicability; minor adjustments suggested	Practical recommendations derived (see Appendix G)	Three illustrative cases developed for Sections 5 and 6

their feedback on the taxonomy's applicability and usefulness for describing and analyzing their setup. After that, the interview focused on using the taxonomy to discuss how the BPM practitioners navigate the two tensions in their organizations. This allowed us to go beyond static classification and enabled discussions about how organizations manage context-sensitive trade-offs around BPM-G. Besides insights into the usefulness of the taxonomy, we found the interviews to generate ideas on concrete practices to address the tensions. We clustered their statements thematically and aggregated them towards a set of eight practical recommendations for the design of BPM-G, which can be found in Appendix G.

Third and finally, we used the taxonomy to build and describe three illustrative cases (Kundisch et al. 2021). To do so, we conducted additional semi-structured interviews with BPM practitioners I1, I4, and I9. In contrast to step two, the primary goal in this step was not to gather general feedback on the taxonomy. Instead, we aimed to use it for in-depth discussions about the BPM-G setup at hand. We started by letting each interviewee describe their BPM-G using the taxonomy, followed by targeted questions challenging the interviewee on specific design decisions, and trying to reveal underlying rationales and contextual factors influencing the design. Based on their answers, we were able to build thick descriptions of the three organizations' BPM-G. In Section 5, we present the three illustrative cases and summarize the findings of all demonstration and evaluation steps in a synopsis.

Tension	Dimension	E/N	Characteristics				
Centralization vs. decentralization	Organizational anchoring	N	BPM team in a dedicated department	BPM team in non-dedicated department(s)	BPM community of practice		Individual BPM practitioners
	BPM ownership	N	Senior management	BPM team	BPM community of practice		Not defined
	Financial resources	N	Global BPM budget	Project-based BPM budget	Process-based BPM budget		Not defined
	Leading activities	N	Design & modeling	Monitoring & control	Improvement & innovation	Program & project management	None
	Supporting activities	N	Design & modeling	Monitoring & control	Improvement & innovation	Program & project management	None
	Institutionalization of ambidexterity	E	Separated		Integrated		None
Standardization vs. flexibilization	Process ownership	E	Pre-defined for all processes		Pre-defined per process (type)		Flexible
	Data ownership	E	Pre-defined for all processes	Pre-defined per process (type)		Flexible	Not defined
	Role allocation	N	Per business department(s)	Per BPM activity		Per end-to-end process	Flexible
	Standards & methods	E	Pre-defined for all processes		Pre-defined per process (type)		Flexible
E = exclusive; N = non-exclusive							

Fig. 3 Tensions, dimensions, and characteristics of BPM-G

4 Taxonomy of Business Process Management Governance

We now present the taxonomy of BPM-G (Fig. 3), which is structured along two organizational tensions as layers, i.e., *centralization vs. decentralization* and *standardization vs. flexibilization*, and consists of ten dimensions (six non-exclusives and four exclusives) and 39 characteristics. Below, we go through each layer, elaborate on the dimensions and characteristics, and provide guiding questions as well as insights into the data relating to each dimension with exemplary quotes from the interviews and justificatory references (Tables 3 and 4).

4.1 Centralization Vs. Decentralization

Centralization vs. decentralization is a widespread tension that occurs in corporate governance (Hernaus et al. 2016; Fischer et al. 2020; Siggelkow and Levinthal 2003). An organizational structure is decentralized when decision-making and coordination are disaggregated into several subunits or divisions, making their own decisions. In contrast, a centralized organization is characterized by people making decisions that apply to the entire organization at one level. In our taxonomy of BPM-G, the layer *centralization vs. decentralization* includes six design dimensions.

The dimension of *organizational anchoring* reflects the heart of an organization's BPM-G. It describes the unit, team, department, or group of people primarily practicing and engaging in BPM. One characteristic refers to building a BPM team in a dedicated unit, such as a centralized BPM center of excellence (Rosemann 2015).

Table 3 Guiding questions, quotes and justificatory references for the layer centralization vs. decentralization

Dimension	Guiding Question	Exemplary quote from the interviews	Justificatory references
Organizational anchoring	How is BPM structurally institutionalized within the organization?	<i>“[We] have established the topic of business process management as an independent organizational unit for about seven years, and it has been managed in this way up to now”</i> (I1)	Harmon (2016); Rosemann (2015); Santana et al. (2011); Dyer et al. (2013); von Rosing et al. (2014)
BPM ownership	Which organizational unit or role has authority over your BPM function?	<i>“At the very top, of course, is the executive management, and these are the reporting levels or escalation paths that we set up”</i> (I17)	de Boer et al. (2015); Doebeli et al. (2011); Vom Brocke et al. (2014); von Rosing et al. (2014); (Scott et al. (2012); Luyckx (2009)
Financial resources	How are financial resources allocated for BPM activities?	<i>“Basically, the departments have the entire budget for implementation, the quality management and the process management have [...] a budget for overarching topics”</i> (I1)	Lehnert et al. (2016); Kirchmer et al. (2013)
Leading activities	In which BPM activities does the BPM function have a leading role?	<i>“So right now, of course, there is still a lot of doing because we are just building it up, but the goal should be that the operational becomes less and less, and that goes into the other hands, and then we tend to support [...]”</i> (I8)	Rosemann and Vom Brocke (2015); Santana et al. (2011); Kirchmer et al. (2013); ABPMP International (2020)
Supporting activities	In which BPM activities does the BPM function have a supporting role?	<i>“[It] is actually desired that the employees can also enter their process changes bottom-up [...]. So we are often called in to advise [...]”</i> (I5)	Alibabaei (2021); Rosemann and Vom Brocke (2015); Santana et al. (2011); Kirchmer et al. (2013); ABPMP International (2020)
Institutionalization of ambidexterity	How does the organization differentiate between exploitative and explorative activities?	<i>“There is a distinction being made. [...] [T]he daily business focuses on these small improvements. These big, radical changes [concern the] [...] the topic of digitalization, which has gained more attention in the last years [...]. For digital topics, we have our own team that takes care of those”</i> (I1)	Grisold et al. (2019); Grisold et al. (2022); Helbin and van Looy (2021); O'Reilly and Tushman (2011); Rosemann (2020); (2014)

Another characteristic of a BPM team is that it is in a non-dedicated department, e.g., the IT department (e.g., Harmon 2016). If an organization decides to increase the decentralization of its BPM, it can build a BPM community of practice or promote individual BPM practitioners. A BPM community of practice refers to an ecosystem of BPM practitioners who frequently communicate and share how the organization manages its processes. In turn, individual BPM practitioners rarely or never communicate with each other. The dimension of *BPM ownership* refers to the organizational unit or role with authority and guidance over an organization's BPM, i.e., the people supporting and executing BPM activities (de Boer et al. 2015). This includes, for instance, aligning BPM with the organization's overall strategy

or deciding on improvements for the BPM-G. BPM ownership can be held by senior management or by the dedicated BPM team. Besides, organizations can assign shared, decentralized BPM ownership across the BPM community of practice or define no BPM ownership at all. As BPM ownership is non-exclusive, ownership can be split between multiple functions.

The next dimension addresses how an organization allocates *financial resources* for BPM (Kirchmer et al. 2013; Lehnert et al. 2016). With a global BPM budget, the BPM team can freely use one central budget. Further, organizations can provide project-based BPM budgets, such as budgets for strategic BPM projects (Lehnert et al. 2016). The process-based BPM budget refers to allocating financial resources to a specific process or process type, e.g., by defining a budget for all customer processes. Finally, some organizations do not define a separate budget for BPM, and BPM decision-makers must draw on other financial resources, e.g., budgets from business departments that use the services provided by a BPM team. The following two dimensions of this layer focus on the responsibilities of an organization's BPM (i.e., as defined for the dimension of *organizational anchoring*) for the activities of the BPM lifecycle. Drawing from Rosemann and Vom Brocke (2015), we suggest the activities process design and modeling, implementation and execution, control and measurement, improvement and innovation, and project and program management. We exclude the implementation and execution activity in our taxonomy as we found no clear relation between BPM-G and this activity in our data. Instead, tasks related to implementation and execution primarily refer to the process level, where the process owner manages the process in daily business. In this context, we focus on *leading activities* and *supporting activities* of an organization's BPM. Therein, the BPM of an organization can lead and support the same activity, indicating that organizations can be flexible regarding their allocation of responsibilities for processes or projects. When a BPM team leads an activity, it is responsible for the operational execution of the task. For a supporting activity, the BPM team helps in the operational execution but is not responsible for fulfilling the activity.

Lastly, organizations can choose whether and how to implement ambidextrous activities in their BPM. Ambidexterity in BPM (Grisold et al. 2022) describes the strategy of pursuing both exploitative, i.e., improving existing processes, and explorative BPM, i.e., innovating and exploring novel opportunities for process improvement (Grisold et al. 2019; Rosemann 2014). The dimension *institutionalization of ambidexterity* refers to how an organization implements ambidexterity. We found that organizations can implement ambidexterity in BPM via separate teams, focusing on exploitation or exploration. Otherwise, one team can execute both exploitation and exploration. Further, some organizations do not explicitly consider ambidexterity in their BPM.

4.2 Standardization Vs. Flexibilization

Standardization vs. flexibilization is a pervasive tension in corporate governance, particularly with regard to how roles and structures of organizations are designed and implemented across different units (Cameron 1986; Howard-Grenville 2005). While standardization aims to ensure global coherence, stability, and efficiency across

Table 4 Guiding questions, quotes and justificatory references for the layer standardization vs. flexibilization

Dimension	Guiding Questions	Exemplary quote from the interviews	Justificatory references
Process ownership	How is the ownership of processes allocated?	<i>"It depends on where the trigger came from. If it is a customer request, it depends on whether it is a complaint, for example. It then goes to the existing unit that is also in charge there, and this must then check how the problem can be fixed"</i> (I10)	Alibabaei (2021); Danilova (2019); de Boer et al. (2015); Scott et al. (2012)
Data ownership	How is the ownership of process data allocated?	—*	Kerpedzhiev et al. (2021); Martin et al. (2021); Kirchmer et al. (2013)
Role allocation	How are roles allocated for BPM activities?	<i>"We set ourselves up to be assigned to end-to-end processes"</i> (I4)	Santana et al. (2011); Valenca et al. (2013); Kirchmer et al. (2013)
Standards & methods	How are standards and methods selected regarding the BPM function?	<i>"We develop the framework, design templates, and make basic decisions regarding tools and non-tools"</i> (I19)	Doebeli et al. (2011); Kerpedzhiev et al. (2021); Santana et al. (2011); Kirchmer et al. (2013); Khusidman (2010)

*: We derived this dimension in a C2E iteration and could therefore not attribute a quote

the organization, flexibilization emphasizes adaptability, contextual responsiveness, and local autonomy. The layer *standardization vs. flexibilization* comprises four dimensions.

We found *process ownership* to be a relevant dimension for BPM-G (e.g., Danilova 2019). In contrast to BPM ownership, process ownership does not refer to who holds the role but to how an organization assigns the process owner role. For instance, the BPM owner can assign process ownership to the same responsible unit for all processes, such as assigning the role to the business department most involved in each process. In other cases, the organization standardizes process ownership for specific process types, e.g., the person responsible for a customer group holds ownership of respective customer processes. Further, the assignment of process ownership can be flexible for all processes. Considering the increasing importance of data in BPM that research emphasizes, e.g., for process mining, we derived *data ownership* as a relevant dimension in our first C2E iteration (Kerpedzhiev et al. 2021). We thereby refer to the data extracted during the execution of a process, e.g., process log files. The corresponding dimension describes how an organization assigns the data owner's role. The BPM of an organization can pre-define data ownership for all processes, pre-define it by process type, or leave ownership flexible for all processes. Some organizations have not yet defined data ownership.

Finally, the dimension of *role allocation* refers to how an organization allocates roles for BPM activities. Organizations can allocate corresponding roles per business department, e.g., one member of the BPM unit being assigned to take care of processes for human resources. Equally, organizations can allocate roles per BPM activity, e.g., process analysts responsible for process monitoring (Valenca et al.

2013). Roles can also focus on a specific department and be dedicated to a particular BPM activity. Further, the BPM of an organization can allocate roles per end-to-end processes or opt for a flexible allocation, which depends, for example, on the process type or business unit. The last dimension refers to implementing *standards and methods* (Kerpedzhiev et al. 2021). Organizations can pre-define standards and methods for all processes, e.g., providing a portfolio of methods and tools that stakeholders use when conducting BPM-related activities. Further, an organization can pre-define standards and methods per process (type), e.g., by providing a portfolio of process innovation methods for customer-facing processes. At last, an organization can also decide to implement no standards and methods and allow for flexibility, leaving the choice of methods to the stakeholders involved (Doebeli et al. 2011).

5 Demonstration and Evaluation of the Taxonomy

Our demonstration and evaluation consisted of three steps. We classified the BPM-G setup of 14 organizations, conducted ten additional expert interviews, and built three illustrative cases. In the following, we present the illustrative cases before summarizing the results of all steps in a synopsis.

5.1 Illustrative Cases

We used our taxonomy to build three illustrative cases (Kundisch et al. 2021; Limaj and Bernroider 2022), validating its applicability and usefulness for analyzing BPM-G design decisions and their relation to organizational context. To do so, we contacted the BPM practitioners of three organizations that represent distinct contextual settings and conducted additional interviews with each of them: a mobility and transport organization (henceforth: TRANSPORT, I1); a globally operating organization in the food industry (henceforth: FOOD, I4); and a financial service operator (henceforth: FINANCE, I9). TRANSPORT has a long history of BPM but recently reorganized its BPM department. FOOD was undergoing an organization-wide transformation process to upscale its BPM efforts, and FINANCE had already achieved high BPM maturity, focusing on targeted improvements. We asked each practitioner to detail their BPM-G setup using the taxonomy's dimensions, detail contextual factors and explain design decisions, e.g., if and how the internal and external environment influenced them to address tensions in a certain way. We present the BPM-G setup of each case with our taxonomy (Figs. 4, 5, and 6) and provide a narrative of why the setup was chosen.

5.1.1 The Case of TRANSPORT

TRANSPORT is a mobility and transport organization within a highly uncertain, competitive, and regulated environment. TRANSPORT offers mobility services to an international customer base. It is highly affected by the digital transformation of its industry, such as an increase in customer expectations and streamlining of services. Due to the number of regulations laid upon TRANSPORT by policymakers,

Tension	Dimension	E/N	Characteristics								
Centralization vs. decentralization	Organizational anchoring	N	BPM team in a dedicated department		BPM team in non-dedicated department(s)		BPM community of practice		Individual BPM practitioners		
	BPM ownership	N	Senior management		BPM team		BPM community of practice		Not defined		
	Financial resources	N	Global BPM budget		Project-based BPM budget		Process-based BPM budget		Not defined		
	Leading activities	N	Design & modeling		Monitoring & control		Improvement & innovation		Program & project management		None
	Supporting activities	N	Design & modeling		Monitoring & control		Improvement & innovation		Program & project management		None
	Institutionalization of ambidexterity	E	Separated				Integrated			None	
Standardization vs. flexibilization	Process ownership	E	Pre-defined for all processes			Pre-defined per process (type)			Flexible		
	Data ownership	E	Pre-defined for all processes			Pre-defined per process (type)			Flexible		Not defined
	Role allocation	N	Per business department(s)			Per BPM activity			Per end-to-end process		Flexible
	Standards & methods	E	Pre-defined for all processes			Pre-defined per process (type)			Flexible		
E = exclusive; N = non-exclusive											

Fig. 4 BPM-G setup of TRANSPORT

the primary goal of their BPM activities is to ensure compliance, efficiency, and the training of employees to meet compliance goals.

TRANSPORT addresses the *centralization vs. decentralization* tension by operating BPM in a dedicated department with a project-based budget, mainly focusing on design and modeling for the business departments. The BPM department leads these activities to ensure compliance with regulatory documentation requirements, as expressed by the vice president for quality management of TRANSPORT: “There are [...] various regulated standards that we have to meet and that require us to document and implement process steps properly and that our employees [...] have the same information status at all times” (I1). With its portfolio of activities, the BPM department takes on a traditional, process- and compliance-oriented role with a predominantly exploitative focus on BPM. It operates in the service industry and has an abundance of customer-facing processes. Thus, ensuring and improving the quality of these processes is a major priority, especially since digital solutions have been included in customer relationship management, which came with increasing customer expectations that must be met. “[...] [It, i.e., quality and process management] should rather serve the internal improvement to such an extent that our customers become more and more satisfied and customer loyalty is strengthened” (I1).

With the adoption of BPM, TRANSPORT started establishing and documenting end-to-end processes. To allow the BPM department to focus on this task, TRANSPORT deployed a separate unit to digital initiatives that deal with the more radical, explorative improvement of processes using digital technologies. Therefore, while collaboration is ensured between both units, exploration within BPM is allocated to another department and not part of the central BPM department. In terms of the *standardization vs. flexibilization* tension, the organization assigns roles rigidly. Given the highly regulated contextual environment in which it operates, TRANS-

PORT maintains standards to fulfill the compliance requirements. To this end, it pre-defines process ownership for all processes so that each process has a dedicated, responsible role. Standards and methods for processes are also pre-defined per process since some processes fall under special regulations and, as a result, need to be handled in a particular manner.

5.1.2 The Case of FOOD

FOOD is an internationally operating organization in the highly competitive environment of the food industry. FOOD is in the process of scaling up its BPM activities and transforming its BPM-G setup as part of a strategic initiative promoted by senior management. The overall goal for its BPM is to establish a strategic center of excellence that drives efficiency and innovation. Since FOOD has just started introducing BPM to the organization, the focus of their BPM-G is to increase accessibility and acceptance of BPM and start training employees to develop capabilities.

Overall, FOOD strives for a sophisticated yet flexible setup that allows employees to adapt to the new practice related to BPM. Concerning *centralization vs. decentralization*, FOOD established a BPM team in a dedicated department as a first step of the initiative. BPM ownership is allocated to senior management to maintain strategic importance in the upscaling phase. The centralized department and the ownership located in senior management allow them to centrally manage BPM initiatives and consistently introduce new approaches in the organization due to their decision-making power. Thereby, FOOD wants its BPM department to act as a center of excellence for process improvement and innovation while supporting decentralized process owners. The BPM department should, therefore, be able to handle both efficiency-driven improvement initiatives and radical innovation activities, i.e., an integrated institutionalization of ambidexterity: “*Since our company has a product that goes directly to the customer, customer orientation is extremely important to us. Thus, our process landscape is oriented towards the customer and not towards product development first. On the other hand, I would say that we have many projects that are [...] driven inside-out; therefore, my answer is: ‘Yes, we do both’*” (I4).

To maximize the impact of the BPM department’s initiative, FOOD adopted an end-to-end process perspective on role allocation, breaking up the traditional silo-like approach where separate departments own and operate certain parts of each process. Although FOOD made profound structural changes to homogenize its way of managing business processes, it continued to handle process ownership and the use of standards and methods rather flexibly for two reasons. First, they wanted their BPM department to be like an in-house consulting unit that cycles through end-to-end processes for improvement and innovation. However, the daily operation of these processes, i.e., design and modeling, and monitoring and control, was still up to the responsible business departments. Second, while the BPM department can provide suggestions for which standards or methods might be optimal in daily business to preserve employee acceptance of the BPM initiative, following these suggestions is not mandatory for the departments. The only exception was data ownership. As

Tension	Dimension	E/N	Characteristics				
Centralization vs. decentralization	Organizational anchoring	N	BPM team in a dedicated department	BPM team in non-dedicated department(s)	BPM community of practice	Individual BPM practitioners	
	BPM ownership	N	Senior management	BPM team	BPM community of practice	Not defined	
	Financial resources	N	Global BPM budget	Project-based BPM budget	Process-based BPM budget	Not defined	
	Leading activities	N	Design & modeling	Monitoring & control	Improvement & innovation	Program & project management	None
	Supporting activities	N	Design & modeling	Monitoring & control	Improvement & innovation	Program & project management	None
	Institutionalization of ambidexterity	E	Separated		Integrated		None
Standardization vs. flexibilization	Process ownership	E	Pre-defined for all processes		Pre-defined per process (type)		Flexible
	Data ownership	E	Pre-defined for all processes		Pre-defined per process (type)		Flexible
	Role allocation	N	Per business department(s)		Per BPM activity		Flexible
	Standards & methods	E	Pre-defined for all processes		Pre-defined per process (type)		Flexible

E = exclusive; N = non-exclusive

Fig. 5 BPM-G setup of FOOD

FOOD acknowledged the increasing importance of analyzing their process data, they centrally allocate data ownership for certain process types.

5.1.3 The Case of FINANCE

FINANCE is an internationally operating financial services and products provider. It established BPM five years ago and has achieved a high level of BPM maturity. Since the organization operates in a highly regulated environment and is part of a group of companies, its parent company pre-defines the corporate governance and BPM-G setup for most dimensions. Additionally, a change in senior management roles at FINANCE brought a heightened strategic emphasis on BPM. As I9 puts it: “BPM has made it all the way to the top. We never had such an influence on our strategy before”.

FINANCE implemented a highly centralized BPM-G setup. BPM is operated in a dedicated department that takes on monitoring and control as well as improvement and innovation in a leading role, as it is deemed fit to monitor compliance regulations implemented by the parent company. Additionally, it is easier for the BPM department to steer improvement and innovation initiatives since they often originate from monitoring activities. Due to FINANCE’s high maturity level of BPM, the business units are capable of managing the design and modeling activities on their own, while the BPM team offers support in these activities. The pre-defined standards and methods for BPM meanwhile ensure the compliance of process documentation within the business units.

FINANCE needs to manage an abundance of business departments and their overarching end-to-end processes. Senior management, therefore, holds the ownership of BPM to have a central overview and steering power over BPM initiatives. While FINANCE’s BPM had a traditional focus on process documentation for many years,

Tension	Dimension	E/N	Characteristics								
Centralization vs. decentralization	Organizational anchoring	N	BPM team in a dedicated department		BPM team in non-dedicated department(s)		BPM community of practice		Individual BPM practitioners		
	BPM ownership	N	Senior management		BPM team		BPM community of practice		Not defined		
	Financial resources	N	Global BPM budget		Project-based BPM budget		Process-based BPM budget		Not defined		
	Leading activities	N	Design & modeling	Monitoring & control		Improvement & innovation		Program & project management		None	
	Supporting activities	N	Design & modeling	Monitoring & control		Improvement & innovation		Program & project management		None	
	Institutionalization of ambidexterity	E	Separated			Integrated			None		
Standardization vs. flexibilization	Process ownership	E	Pre-defined for all processes			Pre-defined per process (type)			Flexible		
	Data ownership	E	Pre-defined for all processes		Pre-defined per process (type)		Flexible		Not defined		
	Role allocation	N	Per business department(s)		Per BPM activity		Per end-to-end process		Flexible		
	Standards & methods	E	Pre-defined for all processes			Pre-defined per process (type)			Flexible		
E = exclusive; N = non-exclusive											

Fig. 6 BPM-G setup of FINANCE

ever since the introduction of process mining, FINANCE's focus shifted towards streamlining processes in the customer journey. Therefore, explorative activities are handled by a team separate from BPM. A research team that can act upon the incentive from the BPM team and other teams provides input for digital trends and process improvement. Ambidexterity is thus separately institutionalized. Since FINANCE is exposed to regulations that its parent company and its industry oppose, it standardizes most roles and methods within its setup. This standardization is made possible by the high degree of maturity that FINANCE's BPM has acquired over the years.

5.2 Synopsis of the Demonstration and Evaluation of the Taxonomy

Through three steps of demonstration and evaluation, our goal was to evaluate the applicability and usefulness of the taxonomy. We conclude that the taxonomy was easily applicable during all evaluation activities. In the first step, we calculated Cohen's Kappa (Landis and Koch 1977) and the hit ratio (Moore and Benbasat 1991) to validate the reliability when applying the taxonomy. With an average of 0.5409 for Cohen's Kappa, the agreement between raters is considered moderate (Landis and Koch 1977). The average hit ratio was 63.89%, meaning that almost 64% of the time, the characteristics of a BPM-G setup were placed correctly by the researcher compared to the practitioner (Moore and Benbasat 1991). This shows that while the taxonomy is reliable to an acceptable extent, a deep knowledge of an organization's BPM-G is necessary to classify it correctly. The applicability of the taxonomy was also confirmed by the practitioners' qualitative feedback, e.g., "*The taxonomy makes a coherent impression for me. I can directly place our organization in it*" (I25). During step one, we received three responses stating that the classification was complex due to the size of the respective organization. Conversations with

those BPM practitioners revealed that they had separate BPM-G setups per division. In such cases, we recommend applying the taxonomy several times to describe the BPM-G setup of each division.

We also found the taxonomy useful for systematically describing and analyzing specific BPM-G setups. The practitioners confirmed the taxonomy's usefulness as an instrument for specifying their BPM-G, reflecting on the rationales behind each choice, and designing a desired target state. The interviewee of FOOD stated: "[...][We] actually do have discussions about this [i.e., the BPM-G setup] and in this situation, you can take this [the taxonomy] with you for further support saying 'Look, this is not only our perspective but these results are enriched with insights from other companies, too'" (I4). The discussions with the BPM practitioners also showed that the taxonomy is a useful tool to learn more about the relation between BPM-G and its context. We will revert to related insights in Section 6. In sum, we conclude that the taxonomy is valid regarding both evaluation criteria and identified ideas for improvement, which we will outline in Section 7.

6 Discussion

Adopting BPM at the enterprise level is more important than ever to manage business processes in constantly shifting environments (Baiyere et al. 2020). However, building an effective BPM-G that provides clear guidance, boundaries, and continuity for BPM activities is an understudied domain (Kerpedzhiev et al. 2021). One key challenge is that BPM-G cannot be designed in isolation (Vom Brocke et al. 2016; 2022). As a cross-functional management discipline that aims to improve and monitor business processes, BPM is strongly connected to, but also dependent on corporate governance and process governance (de Bruin and Rosemann 2007; Hammer 2015; Rosemann and Vom Brocke 2015).

Against this drawback, we set out to investigate the research question of *how BPM-G can be conceptualized and how it relates to its context*. Regarding the first part of the question, we developed a taxonomy of BPM-G based on rich empirical data from interviews and justificatory knowledge from the BPM and corporate governance literature. Our findings show that organizational tensions influence the design of BPM-G (Gaim et al. 2018), a common challenge of all governance forms, as organizations need to balance control and autonomy (Fama and Jensen 1998). We evaluated the taxonomy by categorizing the BPM-G of 14 organizations, conducting ten additional interviews, and presenting three illustrative cases to illustrate its usefulness for gathering novel insights on how organizations design their BPM-G.

Below, we explicitly address the second part of our research question (Section 6.1). To do so, we synthesize the key findings of our study and compare them against the literature on BPM and corporate governance to advance a context-aware understanding of BPM-G. More specifically, we discuss its intersection with the broader corporate governance that spans organizational structures, as well as with the more operational process governance that ensures the day-to-day execution of business processes. Thereafter, we summarize our contributions (Section 6.2),

highlight theoretical implications (Section 6.3), and point out practical implications (Section 6.4).

6.1 Towards a Context-aware Understanding of Business Process Management Governance

One observation that consistently stood out throughout all interviews is the dependence of BPM-G on its context. Almost all experts mentioned ongoing struggles in BPM adoption and that their BPM-G needed to be iteratively adjusted in response to changing conditions in the internal and external environment. This observation reflects our earlier definition of context as the interplay of internal and external demands that are multi-dimensional and evolve over time, linking BPM-G to both corporate and process governance. For example, I22 stated: “*We are [...] a very customer-oriented company, and we have always been very responsive to the customers’ needs [...] until we became so big that we realized we could no longer do this in such an individual way. And then, of course, you first need to realize what needs to be changed to solve this in the long term [...]*”. In this regard, our results strongly support findings in the literature that BPM needs to be institutionalized in a context-aware manner (Rosemann et al. 2006; Vom Brocke et al. 2021a; Zelt et al. 2019). We extend these discussions by specifying the central role of BPM-G in operationalizing context-awareness.

To illustrate the context-aware understanding of BPM-G that we put forward, we present Fig. 7 as an updated version of the conceptual framework shown in Section 2.3 (see Fig. 2). A recurring pattern in our data is that the overarching tension of corporate governance to balance control and autonomy manifests for BPM-G as two specific tensions. At the interface with corporate governance, BPM-G must address the tension between *centralization vs. decentralization*, i.e., how authority is delegated to a BPM unit and how it is steered and held accountable. At the interface with process governance, BPM-G shapes how BPM interacts with more operational

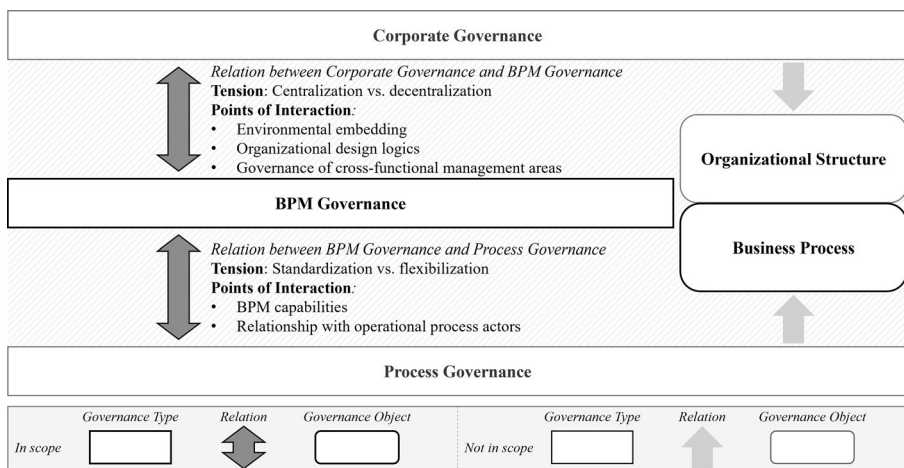


Fig. 7 Conceptual framework—Situating BPM-G, the taxonomy and tensions within its contexts

process roles (e.g., process owners), thereby navigating the tension between *standardization vs. flexibilization*.

On the relation between BPM-G and corporate governance. In terms of the tension of *centralization vs. decentralization*, we found three points of interaction between BPM-G and corporate governance: (1) environmental embedding, (2) organizational design logics, and (3) the governance of cross-functional management areas.

The first point of interaction lies in their mutual embeddedness in the organizational environment. We observe that external pressures, such as regulatory changes, trigger not only changes in corporate governance but also shifts in how centralized or decentralized BPM-G is designed. The governance literature recognizes such context sensitivity as a central tenet (Ostrom 2005; Aguilera and Jackson 2003), particularly for environments characterized by institutional pluralism, i.e., the coexistence of conflicting expectations and constraints from different stakeholders (Greenwood et al. 2011). BPM-G responds to how corporate governance receives these external stimuli and translates them into specific changes to how business processes are managed. BPM-G becomes the relay point through which the environment influences not just priorities, hierarchies, and structures in corporate governance, but also process-related decision-making and responsibilities. Our illustrative cases of TRANSPORT and FINANCE demonstrate this interaction, as both operate in highly regulated industries, resulting in a centralized BPM-G with a strong emphasis on standardized documentation and compliance. Another example from our interviews includes an energy provider that highlights the importance of stability in BPM adoption: “*The nature of our business is the energy transition, which means that these are big issues that will take a long time to resolve. As a company, this means that we have to move a little slower [regarding BPM adoption] because we need to create something stable*” (I26).

Second, while BPM-G derives its boundaries from corporate governance, it can also influence corporate governance by introducing new coordination mechanisms, redefining responsibilities, and embedding process thinking into strategic decision-making. Our empirical cases show that such upward influence is often indirect and depends on the maturity of BPM in an organization, e.g., when BPM becomes an enabler of transparency, cross-unit coordination, or compliance. For instance, as shown in the case of FOOD, BPM-G can evolve from a loosely coordinated setup into a formalized, strategic governance function that transforms other reporting lines and authority structures: “*We have 40 national companies, which, historically, have been run more like kingdoms and have all had a degree of freedom. That’s why we had 40 SAP clients, or at least units [...]; and that’s why the need for BPM ultimately arose*” (I4). This shift not only reinforced BPM-G’s credibility but also led to more structured steering and oversight practices at the enterprise level.

The third point of interaction relates to the special role of BPM as a cross-functional management discipline. Our findings illustrate the challenges associated with designing governance for a boundary-spanning function. Unlike functional governance with clear departmental ownership, BPM-G operates across structural boundaries, managing interfaces between business units and departments: “*Especially in the context of digitalization, it is important to look at the overall process and not*

what we always call polishing the islands,” “where everyone defines their own perfect world in their sub-process step, but rather look at the overall process end-to-end, which of course means that we have to establish new roles, etc., and then bring about optimizations [...]” (I27). This position creates unique demands: it requires BPM-G to establish credibility, sometimes without formal authority, and ensure consistency across departments, sometimes without hierarchical control. In the illustrative case of FOOD, we saw an end-to-end process perspective implemented to break down traditional departmental silos and assigned the BPM team explicit responsibility to foster cross-functional collaboration. The underlying challenges resonate with corporate governance discussions on how cross-functional governance arrangements balance configurational fitness and adaptability (Puranam et al. 2012; Greenwood et al. 2011).

On the relation between BPM-G and process governance. In terms of the tension of *standardization vs. flexibilization*, we found two points of interaction between BPM-G and process governance throughout our research: (1) BPM capabilities and (2) the relationship with operational process actors.

First, many interviewees rationalized design decisions at the interface between BPM-G and process governance by referring to the current or target state of their BPM capabilities. They closely monitored their teams’ ability to provide useful tools, guidance, and support for BPM activities, and established standards only where they held, or aimed to build, clear methodological or technical strengths: “*Standardized refers to the meeting structure, the documentation, the way we work—we always call it project mechanics—how projects come about in our company, what criteria are used to evaluate and implement them*” (I22). This is reflected in the case of FINANCE, where a high level of BPM maturity enabled the BPM team to enforce pre-defined standards for business process monitoring and improvement. In contrast, some interviewees noted that in areas where the BPM unit lacked sufficient expertise or had no plans to develop capabilities in the future, they remained deliberately flexible. Consequently, process actors in the business units started to develop these capabilities themselves, while the central BPM unit tried to facilitate knowledge exchange and mutual learning. This capability-centric logic to design governance aligns with literature on dynamic capabilities and governance maturity (Teece 2007), emphasizing that governance should not outpace organizational competence.

Second, the interviewees emphasized the importance of process literacy among process executors and the general sentiment towards BPM among process owners as key factors shaping BPM-G design, particularly in terms of *standardization vs. flexibilization*. For example, in the case of FOOD, the decision to keep the application of standards and methods flexible was a deliberate choice to preserve acceptance and build trust among process owners. Several BPM decision makers thereby highlighted the importance of trust and perceived credibility in deciding for or against establishing standards. Where trust in the process organization was high, BPM units granted greater flexibility to process owners, supporting them with training, toolkits, and optional templates: “*Where it works very well is where there are clearly defined roles. [...] You can see that when the capacity is there, the focus shifts to completely different issues and everything works very quickly*” (I27). Conversely, in settings where process literacy was low, BPM-G often acted as a compensatory structure,

enforcing a high level of standardization. These observations align with findings in the literature suggesting that the degree of standardization is not merely a design variable, but the result of ongoing alignment between normative intentions and the practical experiences and expectations of the process organization (Schmiedel et al. 2020; Greenwood et al. 2011).

6.2 Contribution

The proposed taxonomy is the primary contribution of our study, adding descriptive knowledge to the BPM literature in general and BPM-G in particular. It offers a high-level abstraction and conceptualization (Kundisch et al. 2021), that can enable the systematic description and analysis of BPM-G. In general, taxonomies are valuable tools for making sense of complex and multifaceted phenomena (Graf-Drasch et al. 2022). As a theory for analyzing (Gregor 2006; Kundisch et al. 2021), the taxonomy can help to structure and organize the diversity of design options for BPM-G, offering a conceptualization of relevant dimensions and a basis for further analysis and theory development. In line with Limaj and Bernroider (2022), we argue that the generic nature of our taxonomy makes it a useful tool to describe BPM-G setups over time and across settings. However, the taxonomy can not only be used to describe specific BPM-G setups in organizations, but also to identify common patterns of why organizations choose specific combinations of design options. We demonstrated this particularly through our illustrative cases, where we used the taxonomy as an analysis tool to structure discussions with practitioners and learn more about why they designed their BPM-G the way it is.

The secondary contribution of our study lies in adding to a context-aware understanding of BPM-G by offering initial, empirically informed insights on two tensions. Prior research has shown that context-awareness is a critical success factor for adopting and practicing BPM in the digital age (Vom Brocke et al. 2021b; Edvardsson et al. 2018; Baiyere et al. 2020; Schmiedel et al. 2020). We highlight the important role of BPM-G for context-awareness, as it represents how BPM is organized and connected to corporate and process governance. While the existence of tensions in any form of governance is known, we identify the specific tensions that are paramount for the relation between BPM-G and its context and link these tensions to design dimensions. Drawing on the theoretical foundations presented in Section 2 (e.g., Foss 2003; Puranam et al. 2012; Smith and Lewis 2011), we argue that BPM-G needs to address the tension of *centralization vs. decentralization* at the interface with corporate governance and *standardization vs. flexibilization* at the interface with process governance. In doing so, our study provides an initial contextualized and empirically grounded understanding of BPM-G as a specific governance form that needs to co-evolve with its organizational environment. We lay the groundwork for a more nuanced understanding of BPM-G that not only captures its structural variety but also explains its adaptive capacity considering organizational tensions and contextual contingencies.

6.3 Theoretical Implications

While existing knowledge on BPM-G remains important and valuable, our study suggests that it is essential to theorize on it comprehensively, considering organizational dependencies and tensions. Given the scarce knowledge of BPM-G, our results offer two theoretical implications.

First, our results provide several opportunities for further theorizing on BPM-G (Gregor 2006). Regarding theories of explaining (i.e., Type II), we recommend empirically inferring common configurations of BPM-G setups based on the taxonomy, i.e., archetypes (El Sawy et al. 2010). Future work could examine how those archetypes relate to performance outcomes in specific contexts (van Looy et al. 2022). Regarding theories for predicting (i.e., Types III-IV), we argue that while our taxonomy is sufficiently generic to endure for a considerable period, we acknowledge the potential for future changes. Longitudinal and larger-scale studies may enable more informed assumptions about how BPM-G evolves (Kerpedzhiev et al. 2021; Baiyere et al. 2020). Regarding theories for design and action (i.e., Type V), we see our results as a first step that may inform the development of design principles in future work. Taxonomies can serve an abstraction of design spaces by conceptualizing design decisions at a high-level (Gross et al. 2021). However, a full-fledged design space analysis (MacLean et al. 1993; 1991) would require in-depth studies of the taxonomy's dimensions to identify fine-grained design options. The practical recommendations derived in our evaluation (see Appendix G) should therefore be understood as illustrative insights rather than prescriptive guidance, offering starting points for further design-oriented research.

Second, other scholars can build on our results to conduct in-depth research into the relations demonstrated in our conceptual framework and better understand the intricacies of the three governance forms. One approach could be to conduct longitudinal studies examining different pathways of BPM adoption while tracking related changes in context and continuous adjustments to BPM-G and vice versa. This would allow scholars to investigate the relations' validity and add more details on how they unfold in practice. As such, our study should be seen as a starting point to bring the fields of BPM and corporate governance (Gaim et al. 2018; Putnam et al. 2016; Smith et al. 2017) closer together. Although we cannot provide definitive answers on how organizational tensions should be addressed in BPM-G, we incorporated preliminary insights into our theorizing. More investigations are needed to fully understand and explore the relationship between BPM-G and its context.

6.4 Managerial Implications

In addition to the theoretical implications, our study also offers valuable insights for practitioners. We propose two primary managerial implications. First, the taxonomy may serve as a practical tool for supporting managerial decision-making when designing and developing BPM-G during BPM adoption. It can offer a comprehensive overview of different design options and provide practitioners with a framework to describe and discuss their BPM-G setup. For example, one of the organizations in

our sample built a survey based on the taxonomy, in which they asked the members of their process organizations to categorize their current setup as well as outline the target state. The results were then used for subsequent discussions to align everyone on the intended purpose of BPM, explain how BPM-G supports this purpose, and develop a new BPM-G setup that everyone agrees with. We encourage BPM practitioners to avoid searching for a single “ideal” BPM-G setup that will remain valid over any time period. Instead, they could continuously reassess if the current state of BPM-G still aligns with BPM maturity and then adjust specific dimensions if needed. The guiding questions, dimensions, and characteristics that we identified should help BPM practitioners to structure this evaluation process and rationalize their decisions. Therein, our illustrative cases can also be seen as inspiration.

Second, the taxonomy can prompt practitioners to approach governance-related decisions in a context-sensitive manner. Organizations are encouraged to systematically consider their specific organizational context and to regularly evaluate the fit between BPM-G design and the evolving strategic orientation of the organization. This can mitigate the risk of isolated solutions and promote coherence across governance structures. Furthermore, the taxonomy is intended to foster a more deliberate handling of organizational tensions. By explicitly surfacing trade-offs between design decisions, it can help practitioners reflect on and address such tensions in a more structured way, instead of addressing them implicitly or reactively. For example, we observed that BPM often shifts from a purely efficiency-oriented role to one of strategic enablement in the context of digital transformation. This shift often requires organizations to revisit their governance setup to better support cross-functional digital initiatives. The taxonomy can support such transitions by helping practitioners to assess and deliberately redesign BPM-G elements in light of the changing role and objectives of BPM.

7 Limitations and Concluding Remarks

As with any research endeavor, our study has limitations. First, we conducted 34 interviews over the course of all taxonomy development and evaluation activities. Although our sample provided rich information due to the nature and length of the interviews, future research may study a larger sample of organizations to challenge the comprehensiveness of the taxonomy, adjust it accordingly, and enhance its generalizability. At the same time, drawing on a larger sample will also help explore some of the research opportunities we discussed, e.g., the application of a configurational perspective to identify and compare archetypes of BPM-G setups. Second, the dimensions and characteristics of our taxonomy simplify BPM-G in practice since we aim to balance the comprehensiveness and understandability of our results. While we already discussed the benefits of the generic nature of our taxonomy (Limaj and Bernroider 2022), future research should still focus on single dimensions to unfold them in more detail. Additionally, we recognize that our study may suffer from selection bias, as it solely examines organizations with an explicit BPM-G setup, not considering organizations with “shadow BPM”. This limitation should be acknowledged and addressed in future research to provide a more comprehensive

understanding of BPM practices across different organizational contexts. Furthermore, although our newly developed conceptual framework for BPM-G draws on all our data (i.e., the literature and interviews), our related findings should undergo further challenging and scrutinizing.

Turning toward the future, BPM will remain a key driver of business success, helping organizations manage and shape change associated with digital technology. However, we should keep in mind that developing BPM capabilities is a challenging endeavor for organizations, which at its core requires institutionalizing BPM through BPM-G. We hope that our study will contribute to making this task less complicated and that we inspire fellow researchers to join us in investigating and discussing BPM-G, especially embedded in its context.

Supplementary Information The online version of this article (<https://doi.org/10.1007/s41471-026-00241-0>) contains supplementary material, which is available to authorized users.

Funding No funding, grants, or other support was received for this study.

Funding Open Access funding enabled and organized by Projekt DEAL.

Data Availability The data supporting the findings of this study are partially available in the appendix, which contains the materials necessary to understand and reproduce the reported results. Due to confidentiality agreements and the need to protect the anonymity of participating experts and organizations, the original interview data are not publicly accessible.

Declarations

Conflict of interest F. Dechert, F. Friedrich, T. Kreuzer, L. Marcus, C. Ritter and M. Röglinger declare that they have no competing interests.

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